

A LETTER ON FAITHFUL STEWARDSHIP IN CATHOLIC EDUCATION

for the Opening of the Academic Year 2026–2027

Fidelis Cura in Educatione

Faithful Stewardship in Education

**“Whoever is faithful in a very little is faithful also in much;
and whoever is dishonest in a very little is dishonest also in much.”**

Luke 16:10

and

“It is required of stewards that they be found trustworthy.”

1 Corinthians 4:2

I. GREETING AND BLESSING

Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ (1 Corinthians 1:3).

To the Principals, Vice Principals, Teachers, Chaplains, Administrative and Support Staff, Students, Parents, and all who share in the ecclesial mission of Catholic education throughout the Archdiocese of Port of Spain:

At the dawn of this new academic year, I address you with paternal affection and profound gratitude in the Lord. I give thanks to Almighty God for the many men and women who, according to their diverse vocations and responsibilities, dedicate themselves to the education and integral formation of our children and young people. I thank those who govern and lead, those who teach and accompany, those who administer and serve, those who maintain our schools, those who minister sacramentally and pastorally, and those whose faithful service remains unseen yet indispensable.

The mission of Catholic education is not merely an institutional duty or a professional occupation. It is a participation in the Church's maternal and educational mission, a service to the human person, and a work of evangelization. As the Second Vatican Council reminds us, “the future of humanity passes by way of those who are strong enough to provide coming generations with reasons for living and hoping” (*Gravissimum Educationis*, 1).

In our schools, we are called to form the whole person intellectually, morally, spiritually, socially, and culturally, so that young people may discover the truth of their dignity, the meaning of their lives, and their vocation to love God and serve others. As we commence this academic year, I place before us the words of

Saint Paul: “It is required of stewards that they be found trustworthy” (1 Corinthians 4:2). These words summon us to an examination of conscience: everything entrusted to us ultimately belongs to God. Our schools, our authority, our resources, our gifts, our time, our relationships, and above all, the children and young people placed in our care, are gifts for which we shall one day give an account.

The Christian educator is therefore a steward before being an administrator, a teacher, or a professional. Our first responsibility is fidelity to the One who has entrusted the mission to us.

II. THE CATHOLIC SCHOOL AS AN ECCLESIAL COMMUNITY

Catholic education transcends the mere transmission of academic knowledge. The Catholic school is an ecclesial community and a privileged expression of the Church's mission to evangelize and educate. Our schools are called to be places where the Gospel is proclaimed, where the human person is honoured, where truth is pursued, where faith seeks understanding, and where young people encounter Jesus Christ through teaching, prayer, sacramental life, community, service, and the witness of those who accompany them.

The Catholic school exists to educate the whole human person. It seeks the formation of persons capable of communion with God and responsible service of neighbour. As the Church teaches, the Catholic school is a school for the human person and of human persons. For this reason, academic excellence and Christian formation must never be separated. The pursuit of knowledge cannot be divorced from the pursuit of truth, and truth finds its fullness in Jesus Christ.

Our schools must therefore resist every reduction of education to examination results, institutional reputation, technological advancement, or measurable achievement. These have their proper place, yet they are not the ultimate purpose of Catholic education. The deepest question before us is not simply whether our students have learned, but whether through our ministry they have encountered truth, discovered their dignity, grown in wisdom, encountered Christ, and been prepared to live lives of holiness and service. The true measure of Catholic education is faithfulness to the mission entrusted to us.

III. THE STEWARDSHIP ENTRUSTED TO US

The Gospel according to Saint Luke places before us the demanding words of the Lord: “Whoever is faithful in a very little is faithful also in much” (Luke 16:10). The Lord then adds: “No servant can serve two masters” (Luke 16:13). These words reveal both the dignity and seriousness of Christian stewardship.

We are stewards, not owners. Time is entrusted to us. Authority is entrusted to us. Financial and material resources are entrusted to us. Our talents and professional abilities are entrusted to us. Relationships are entrusted to us. Influence is entrusted to us. Above all, the lives and future of young people are entrusted to our care. The *Catechism of the Catholic Church* reminds us that humanity's dominion over creation “is not absolute; it is limited by concern for the quality of life of [our] neighbour and of generations to come” (CCC 2415).

Christian stewardship is therefore always exercised before God and for the good of others. The trustworthy steward asks not merely, “What can I achieve?” but “How faithfully have I used what God has entrusted to me?” This changes the meaning of leadership. Authority becomes service. Administration becomes stewardship. Teaching becomes vocation. Professional excellence becomes an offering. Resources become instruments for mission. The Christian steward seeks faithfulness before recognition, integrity before acclaim, perseverance before applause, and service before self-interest.

IV. HOLINESS IN THE SACRED ORDINARY

The call to holiness is not reserved for extraordinary circumstances. Much of Christian holiness is lived in the ordinary responsibilities entrusted to us each day. Preparing a lesson carefully, beginning a class punctually, maintaining accurate records, welcoming a visitor with dignity, keeping a classroom safe and

orderly, listening patiently to a troubled student, managing resources honestly, treating colleagues respectfully, correcting injustice, forgiving an offence, and carrying out an unseen responsibility faithfully can all become acts of Christian discipleship when offered to God in love.

Saint Thérèse of Lisieux understood this profoundly through her “Little Way.” She discovered that holiness does not depend upon being noticed or celebrated. It is found in doing ordinary things with extraordinary love. This spirituality is particularly appropriate to Catholic education. A school is sustained by thousands of actions that may never receive public recognition. Yet God sees the fidelity of the teacher who prepares late into the evening, the administrator who resolves a difficult problem with patience, the cleaner who cares for the school environment, the secretary who welcomes a distressed parent, the chaplain who listens to a young person in difficulty, and the principal who carries burdens that others may never see.

The Gospel does not ask us first to be impressive. It asks us to be trustworthy.

V. GIFTS FOR THE BUILDING UP OF THE BODY OF CHRIST

The Holy Spirit gives different gifts to different members of the Church. Saint Paul teaches: “To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good” (1 Corinthians 12:7). The diversity of gifts within our educational community is therefore not a problem to be eliminated. It is a gift to be received and ordered toward communion.

Some are gifted in teaching. Others in administration, pastoral care, technology, finance, leadership, counselling, maintenance, communication, music, sport, or practical service. Some gifts are visible, while others remain hidden. No gift is insignificant when it is placed at the service of the mission. The Catholic school must therefore be a community in which gifts are recognized, encouraged, developed, and generously shared. Competition for prestige must never replace collaboration for mission. Our common purpose is greater than any individual position, department, school, or programme. We serve one Lord, one Church, and one mission. Faithful stewardship means therefore not only using our own gifts well but helping others to discover and use theirs.

VI. RESPONSIBLE STEWARDSHIP OF MATERIAL GOODS

The Church's mission requires material resources, and the responsible management of those resources is itself a moral responsibility. At a time of financial pressure and limited resources, every Catholic school is called to exercise prudence, transparency, accountability, and responsible administration. Every classroom, building, book, computer, device, vehicle, financial contribution, and material resource has been entrusted to us for the good of the students and for the fulfilment of the Church's mission.

Pope Francis, particularly in *Laudato Si*, has reminded the Church of the moral responsibility involved in the stewardship of creation and the goods entrusted to humanity. We must therefore resist waste, negligence, misuse, and unnecessary expenditure. We must cultivate gratitude for what we have received and wisdom in how it is used. Financial stewardship is not merely an administrative matter. It is a matter of justice. When resources are managed honestly and prudently, we bear witness to the truth that material goods exist for the service of the human person and the common good.

VII. THE HUMAN PERSON AT THE CENTRE

Above every policy, programme, structure, system, and technological development stands the human person, created in the image and likeness of God. Technology is important. Infrastructure is important. Administration is important. Policies and procedures are important. Yet none of these may become more important than the persons they are intended to serve. The Catholic school must therefore remain profoundly human.

Students deserve dignity. Parents deserve respect. Teachers deserve encouragement. Administrators deserve cooperation. Support staff deserve recognition. Those who struggle deserve patience. Those who are different deserve respect. Those who are vulnerable deserve particular care. Pope Francis has reminded us that education is an act of hope. This hope rests upon the Christian conviction that grace can transform lives and that no young person is beyond the reach of God's mercy.

We must therefore reject every educational culture that reduces a child to grades, performance, behaviour, economic usefulness, or technological profile. Every student is first a person loved by God. In an age increasingly shaped by artificial intelligence and rapidly developing digital technologies, this conviction becomes even more important. The digital environment must serve the human person and the common good. Decisions concerning data, algorithms, platforms, and artificial intelligence must be guided by human dignity, solidarity, justice, responsibility, and concern for future generations. A trustworthy steward never places a system above a soul.

VIII. CHRISTIAN WITNESS: THE FIRST FORM OF EVANGELIZATION

Young people possess a remarkable capacity to recognize authenticity. They recognize honesty. They recognize hypocrisy. They recognize compassion. They recognize indifference. They recognize humility. They recognize when an adult speaks of faith without living it. For many students, the first Gospel they encounter is the life of the teacher, principal, chaplain, administrator, or staff member before them.

Saint Paul VI expressed this truth with memorable clarity: “Modern man listens more willingly to witnesses than to teachers.” The credibility of Catholic education therefore depends not merely upon what we teach, but upon whether our lives correspond to what we proclaim. A teacher who teaches forgiveness but refuses to forgive contradicts the Gospel. A leader who teaches justice but acts unjustly contradicts the Gospel. A school that teaches human dignity while humiliating the vulnerable contradicts the Gospel. A Catholic community that speaks about prayer, but neglects prayer weakens its witness.

Our students must encounter in us the coherence of Christian discipleship. The deepest lesson a young person remembers may not be a particular fact taught in a classroom. It may be the teacher who believed in them, the chaplain who listened to them, the principal who treated them fairly, or the staff member whose quiet faith showed them that Christianity is real. The witness of our lives is therefore an essential part of our educational mission.

IX. FAITHFUL FORMATION: RECEIVING, LIVING, AND HANDING ON THE *KERYGMA*

The Catholic educator cannot hand on faithfully what he or she has not first received. At the heart of Christian formation stands the *kerygma*, (the apostolic proclamation of Jesus Christ, who died for our sins, rose from the dead, and calls every person to conversion, faith, discipleship, and new life in Him). The faith we teach is not simply a body of information. It is the faith of the Church, received from the Apostles, safeguarded in Sacred Scripture and Sacred Tradition, celebrated in the liturgy, articulated in the teaching of the Church, and handed on from one generation to the next.

Every Catholic educator is therefore first a disciple. We are called to receive the Gospel, believe the Gospel, live the Gospel, and hand on the Gospel. We cannot authentically ask our students to pray if prayer has no place in our own lives. We cannot ask them to encounter Christ if we ourselves remain distant from Him. We cannot invite them to participate in the sacramental life of the Church if we ourselves neglect that life. We cannot ask them to live the virtues of charity, forgiveness, truth, justice, and mercy if these virtues are absent from our own conduct.

Formation must therefore begin with conversion of heart. The Catholic educator is called to grow continually in knowledge and love of Jesus Christ, in familiarity with Sacred Scripture, in understanding of the *Catechism* and the teaching of the Church, in participation in the sacramental life, in prayer, and in the witness of the saints. This formation cannot be considered complete with professional qualification or initial religious instruction. Christian formation is lifelong.

I therefore strongly encourage all who serve in Catholic education to participate actively in parish formation programmes, diocesan initiatives, retreats, workshops, Bible study, theological and spiritual programmes, and other opportunities for continuing formation. We should also make responsible use of appropriate contemporary formation resources. Platforms such as **FORMED** can assist educators, families, and students through access to Scripture, Catholic teaching, theological formation, spiritual reflection, the lives of the saints, and other resources that can support the transmission of the Catholic faith.

Such tools are valuable precisely when they lead us more deeply into the life of the Church. Digital resources cannot replace the Eucharist, Confession, prayer, parish community, personal encounter, spiritual accompaniment, or the life of faith lived within the Church. The purpose of formation is ultimately missionary. We are formed so that we may form others. We receive so that we may hand on. We learn so that we may teach. We encounter Christ so that, through our witness, others may encounter Him. In this way, Catholic education participates in the living transmission of the apostolic faith. What we have received must not stop with us. It must be proclaimed, embodied, taught, celebrated, and handed on to the young people entrusted to our care.

X. CHRIST MUST REMAIN AT THE CENTRE

The Lord warns us: “No servant can serve two masters” (Luke 16:13). This warning has relevance for Catholic education. Academic excellence is important. Good administration is important. Financial responsibility is important. Professional standards are important. Technology is important. However, none of these is the ultimate purpose of the Catholic school.

Christ is the centre. As *Gravissimum Educationis* teaches, the knowledge students acquire of the world, life, and humanity is to be illumined by faith. Christ must therefore not be treated as an addition to Catholic education. He is its centre, its foundation, its meaning, and its fulfilment. When Christ is removed from the centre, Catholic education risks becoming merely another educational system. When Christ remains at the centre, every legitimate educational endeavour is ordered toward the dignity of the person.

We must therefore ask continually:

- Are our schools leading young people toward Christ?
- Are our decisions consistent with the Gospel?
- Does our curriculum respect the truth about the human person?
- Does our leadership reflect Christian service?
- Does our discipline reflect justice and mercy?
- Does our community make the presence of Christ visible?

These questions belong at the heart of our examination of conscience.

XI. STEWARDS OF HOPE

The young people entrusted to our schools live in a world marked by rapid social, cultural, economic, technological, and spiritual change. Many carry burdens that remain invisible to us: loneliness, family difficulties, fear concerning the future, uncertainty, social pressure, disappointment, and a longing to belong. Our Catholic schools must therefore become communities of Christian hope.

Hope is not optimism. Christian hope is confidence in God and in His promise of salvation. The educator becomes a steward of this hope when he or she refuses to give up on a student, listens patiently, offers forgiveness, encourages perseverance, protects dignity, and points beyond present difficulties toward the possibility of grace and new life. Our young people need adults who can say, by their lives:

- There is meaning.
- There is truth.
- You are loved.
- You are not alone.

- Your life has a purpose.
- God has not abandoned you.
- Jesus Christ calls you to life.
- The Church believes in your capacity for holiness.

Every act of patience, every word of encouragement, every moment of accompaniment, and every sacrifice made for the good of a young person can become an instrument through which Christ communicates His hope.

XII. A CALL TO FIDELITY

At the beginning of this academic year, I invite every member of our Catholic educational community to renew his or her commitment to faithful stewardship.

- Let us be faithful in our teaching.
- Let us be faithful in our administration.
- Let us be faithful in our financial responsibilities.
- Let us be faithful in our relationships.
- Let us be faithful in prayer.
- Let us be faithful in our formation.
- Let us be faithful in our witness.
- Let us be faithful in proclaiming Jesus Christ.
- Let us be faithful in handing on the faith of the Apostles.
- Let us be faithful in caring for the young people entrusted to us.

Let us remember that fidelity is not measured only in moments of great achievement. It is revealed in the ordinary decisions we make every day. The trustworthy steward is the person who does what is right even when no one is watching.

XIII. A PASTORAL EXHORTATION TO THE CATHOLIC EDUCATIONAL COMMUNITY

- To our principals and school leaders, I entrust the responsibility of building communities marked by communion, justice, accountability, and Christian leadership.
- To our teachers, I entrust the sacred task of forming minds and hearts and of becoming credible witnesses to truth and faith.
- To our chaplains and pastoral ministers, I entrust the ministry of accompanying our young people toward an encounter with Jesus Christ and deeper participation in the life of the Church.
- To our administrative and support staff, I give thanks for the many ways in which your faithful service sustains our schools.
- To our parents, I recall that you are the first educators of your children. The Catholic school exists not in competition with the family, but in partnership with it.
- To our students, I say this: you are not merely recipients of education. You are persons called by God, loved by Him, gifted by Him, and invited to discover the vocation He has prepared for you.

To all of us, I say: let us renew our confidence in the mission entrusted to us.

- Let every classroom become a place where truth is sought.
- Let every office become a place of justice and welcome.
- Let every staff room become a place of fraternity.
- Let every school become a community of faith.
- Let every Catholic educator become a faithful steward.
- Let Christ be known, loved, proclaimed, and served.

XIV. PRAYER FOR THE NEW ACADEMIC YEAR

As we commence this new academic year, let us entrust our schools, our families, our educators, and our students to the providence of Almighty God.

- May He grant our leaders wisdom.
- May He grant our teachers patience and courage.
- May He grant our chaplains holiness and pastoral charity.
- May He grant our parents strength and perseverance.
- May He grant our students a hunger for truth, a love of goodness, and an openness to His grace.
- May He grant to our entire educational community the humility to learn, the courage to change, the wisdom to discern, and the fidelity to persevere.

May we remember the wise exhortation traditionally associated with Saint Ignatius of Loyola: to pray as though everything depended upon God and to work diligently as though everything depended upon us. Christian stewardship unites prayer and labour, trust and responsibility, contemplation and action.

XV. CONCLUSION: TRUSTWORTHY STEWARDS OF THE LORD

The Lord has entrusted to us a precious gift: the children and young people of this Archdiocese. We are not their owners. We are their stewards. One day, we shall render an account before God, not simply of our achievements, our programmes, our examination results, our buildings, or our institutional reputation, but of our fidelity to the mission He entrusted to us.

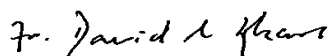
- May He find us trustworthy.
- May He find us faithful in little things and in great things.
- May He find us faithful in what is visible and in what remains hidden.
- May He find us faithful to the Gospel.
- May He find us faithful to the Church.
- May He find us faithful to the young.
- May He find us faithful to Christ.

Then may we hear the words of our Lord: “Well done, good and faithful servant; enter into the joy of your master” (Matthew 25:23). Let the words of Saint Paul remain continually before us: “It is required of stewards that they be found trustworthy” (1 Corinthians 4:2). May Almighty God grant us the grace to live according to this calling.

O Christ, Divine Teacher, walk with us throughout this academic year; increase our faith, strengthen our hope, deepen our charity, purify our intentions, and make fruitful every effort undertaken for the education and formation of our young people. Let the Blessed Virgin Mary, Seat of Wisdom, accompany our schools and families with her maternal care, and let Saint Joseph, faithful guardian of the Holy Family and humble worker, teach us the dignity of faithful service. Grant that all the saints who devoted their lives to the education and formation of the young intercede for us, that our schools may become ever more truly Catholic, ever more deeply human, and ever more faithful to the mission entrusted to us by Christ and His Church.

With confidence in the grace of God and with prayerful gratitude for your service, I commend this new academic year to the Lord.

Given with my prayerful blessing for the opening of the Academic Year 2026–2027 on August 18, 2026.



Reverend Father David S. Khan
Episcopal Vicar for Education
Chief Executive Officer
Catholic Education Board of Management
Archdiocese of Port of Spain.